can they be stopped suddenly? Was there any disciplinary action? Was there a circular sent out by the school? The suddenness of the decision makes it seem like a political conspiracy. At present, four states are going to elections, including Uttar Pradesh, a very important state.

I'm a feminist activist. I'm aware that a woman's body is where patriarchal structures play out politics of religion without consent. And this is true for all religions. As for Muslims, as per Article 25, everyone has the right to practise their religion and the burqa is part of that expression of faith. The question is: do women have the power to choose the clothes or the colours they want to wear? They don't.

This is where "influence" comes in. Muslim women are influenced by their religious identity. After the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992, there were riots across the country. I was a close witness to the riots in Mumbai. Muslims were victims of communal violence, of social and economic displacement and our very existence came under threat. It bred a lot of discussion in the community. Among the questions asked was whether we were being targeted because we were a minority. To overcome that, it was decided that we would display our numbers. The skullcap, the beard and the burqa became the means to exhibit this numerical strength.

Banning the burqa for gender empowerment is an excuse. We are moving towards a Hindu rashtra where democracy is restricted only to elections

It was Islamic fundamentalism being pushed by radical organisations whose agenda was to control women's clothing, mobility and thought. At the same time, however, these very organisations were also the ones helping the victims of the riots. The helping hand, though, also gets the upper hand. That power played a huge role in determining how religion should be enforced and how women had to be symbols of its dignity. And the community more or less accepted these diktats since it was linked to their social security. It is a politics against which I have fought for 35 years now.

I come from a background where no one wears a burqa in the family. No one even wore a burqa in my Urdu-medium school. But, after 1992, I saw a sudden change. Women, including girls as young as four or five, started wearing a burqa. And today, if you speak against it, you will likely face boycott and suffer, possibly at the hands of your own family. I don't want to wear the burqa, my body is my body, no one can impose on it without my consent or use it for religious/ political reasons. But I was in Mumbai, an urban city. I was given the power to express a different opinion. But today if you ask a young girl not to wear a burqa, what will her view be? Her mother, grandmother, everyone in the neighborhood is wearing it. It is then not a question of choice, but a matter of influence. I don't think it can be reversed that easily.

Which brings us back to the Karnataka government's decision. What is its point? If you are asking one section to not wear the burqa, then you must ask everyone to not wear the *ghoonghat*, *bindi*, *mangalsutra*. If you want to bring uniformity, then bring it everywhere. Gender empowerment is just an excuse. We are moving in the direction of a Hindu rashtra where democracy is restricted only to elections.

Girls should be allowed to study, engage in conversation, given space, made to feel confident. If you place restrictions on them, they will answer with defiance.

We are against the burqa, but forcing girls to remove it is very, very wrong. The community is already socio-economically weak and women are stepping out having overcome great difficulty to study, to build an identity. Now, the government wants to force them indoors by promoting fear? Who is this gender empowerment for? Depriving women of education on the basis of the burqa, I feel, is very dangerous. ■



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HIJABS OF THE MIND

The most interesting, rather instructive, aspect of the Udupi 'hijab controversy' has been the way young Hindus chose to register their protest by underlining their own religious identity. "If you are allowed to don the hijab, then we must be allowed our saffron," they said, through word or action. This way, they—rather, their instructors and mentors—managed to direct public imagination to the larger issue of perceived 'Muslim appeasement'. The hijab would be seen as yet another 'undeserved concession' to Muslims, which must be nipped in the bud. The